

**Pit Fighters**

3. Side Gig

By Rick Griffin

Smashwords Edition  
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Paris opened his eyes. Logan's large deer snout came into focus not an inch away from his face, huffing stale air into his nostrils. Paris would have backed up, but he was already maximally dented into a thin stretcher.

"He's alive!" Logan announced and backed away with a grin over his dumb muzzle. Paris still couldn't make out the ceiling, but Kinny the opossum came into view, hovering over him to check.

"Logan? Kinny?" Paris whispered hoarsely, his face hurting as it moved, "what happened?"

"You should have seen yourself," Kinny said, his exclamatory remark delivered in the same dry tone as everything else he said. "You became some kinda mindless berserker bunny, throwing Santiago around the ring like a helium balloon, only to pass out after you finished."

"Really?" Paris asked.

"No you idiot, Santiago hit you so hard he cracked your skull."

Paris blinked. It took a moment for Kinny's sarcasm to register as a joke and not some kind of cruel prank.

"...so I lost," Paris said.

"He remembers!" Logan exclaimed with a clasp of his thick palms, "that's a good sign!"

Paris didn't remember much except Santiago's fist closing in on his face while he stood there like a moron, but he didn't want to rain on Logan's enjoyable time.

“Yes you lost,” Kinny reiterated. “And you had to forfeit on the loser’s bracket by default.”

“What?!” Paris exclaimed, trying to sit up but his everything still aching.

“Don’t worry,” Logan said, pressing hard hoof-like fingers to Paris’s chest, laying him back straight against the cot. “Dyna said he wouldn’t penalize you for it.”

“So you’re now one win, one loss,” Kinny said.

“I…”

Paris pushed past Logan and sat up. His arm jerked back, connected to an IV and heart monitor behind Kinny. The room they stood in had white linoleum floors.

“I’m in the hospital?!” Paris exclaimed.

“That’s where people go when they get injured.” Logan stretched back Paris’s eyelid and squinted. “We sure there’s no brain damage?”

“No, no no!” Paris rose up despite the crackling feeling all around his head. “I can’t be here! They tack the bill to my contract debt!”

“He remembers how things work! No brain damage.”

“They can’t let you *die* when there’s so much more value to extract,” Kinny said. “Not that they wouldn’t, just not in this case.”

Paris huffed and jerked the IV and monitor straps off his arm and chest. The monitor started making an *eeeeeeeee* noise as the pulse flatlined, followed by an alert flashing.

The entire area around Paris’s face felt like he’d laid on it wrong and all

the pins and needles returned in waves instead of all at once. He entered the closet-like bathroom a few feet away and checked under his violet cheek fur—yeah, it looked like they’d sewn his face back on, though Biomender Gel had already diminished the scars. Nevertheless, that he still had any feeling at all was a marvel.

He hoped nobody was about to show him a playback of the fight. He already knew if he’d suffered that kind of injury out on the streets, he’d be wearing a Phantom of the Opera half-mask for the rest of his life.

This could *not* have been cheap.

“I’m not letting them rack up any more than I need,” Paris announced as he left the bathroom. “I can’t *stay* here.”

“Oh, now he forgot that you do eventually leave the hospital.” Logan reached at the foot of the bed and checked his medical chart. Paris snatched it away.

“No, I mean *under contract*. I have to stop my debt from accumulating. I don’t want to be here forever!” He turned back for the bathroom again, but noticed on the table a small, pineapple-laden basket.

“What’s this?” Paris asked, approaching it.

Logan winced. “Santiago said he was *super* sorry.”

A little card hung off the basket with blue yarn. The little cartoon hippo on the front sat upon a broken chair, with *Pobody’s Nerfect* printed underneath. When he opened the card, it played a tinny, faltering single line of *Ode To Joy*. In sloppy script, the inside read, “sorry for breaking your face —

Santiago.”

“How thoughtful,” Paris said, taking on Kinny’s flat tone.

Kinny shrugged. “Well, at the price of fruit today…”

Paris picked up said fruit and turned over the rest of the basket, revealing nothing. “It’s a single pineapple.”

“Still!” Kinny said. “A pineapple.”

“You might wanna eat that within the next day or two cause we don’t have space in the Green room minifridge,” Logan said.

“We have a minifridge?” Paris asked with a tilt of his long ears.

“It doesn’t have any coolant if that’s what you’re wondering.”

Right then, the door opened and a rotund and prickly nurse entered, turning off the alarm. “Oh!” She said, noticing Paris standing at the other end of the room “Thank goodness, I’d thought for a second we’d lost another.”

“Lost another?!” Paris exclaimed, thoughts running through scenarios in which he’d broken his neck and died, or worse!

“Yes!” The hedgehog nurse reached into her medical apron and pulled out a clipboard with an inch-thick stack of paper attached, approximately seven million yellow tabs sticking out the side. “So many of the fighters who wake up in here leave without filling out the proper paperwork.” She handed it over to Paris.

Paris sighed and pulled up a chair.

—



Paris, back on his bunk, cradled the pineapple on his lap. He'd pulled out his duffel bag, a copy of his contract removed. Kinny sat at the console with the copy, looking back and forth between it and the computer screen, tapping away at a calculator the entire time.

Despite his win that morning, Paris was growing nervous about all this Pit Fighter stuff again—the hospital bill turned out to be three thousand drachs. Less than if they didn't have access to Biomender, but not a paltry sum either. And that was his third fight ever! How did anyone ever stay afloat with these kinds of expenses all laid at the fighters' feet?

Logan waved to get Paris's attention and tapped at a black cube hidden in the corner. The thing was shorter than the length of Logan's shin.

"I guess we have a minifridge," Paris said.

"Don't open it unless you have to," Logan said, rapping on it.

"Why not?"

"Taten's keeping his insulin in there."

Paris blinked. He didn't want to think about how much worse things would be if he had ongoing medical needs, so he turned to the opossum.

"Kinny, you have that yet?"

"One sec," Kinny tapped between the calculator and his spreadsheet, then pivoted his butt on the seat to face Paris, one leg crossed over the other. "So, based on the amount of debt you have, which is about ninety thousand drachs..."

Paris winced at the number again.

“...the average amount of spending based on your weight class, and assuming nothing goes too wrong on the way—which you shouldn't but I needed to make this easier to calculate—you can expect to buy out your contract *before* the fifteen-year term is up if you make it to Silver rank. And that'd be around year fourteen.”

“How far is Silver?” Paris shrank, knowing he wouldn't like the answer.

“It goes: green, blue, violet, red, yellow, iron, steel, chrome, copper, bronze, silver, gold, platinum.”

Paris went over those on his fingers, then ran out of fingers just before Kinny reached the appropriate level. “So uh... eleven ranks...”

And he had barely made an adequate showing in Green! "The only way out was up," but *years*? And not even that many less than his total contact term!

“...are you sure about the expenses?” Paris asked.

Kinny nodded.

“What if I didn't spend so much in the company store?”

“You can't avoid it; they're locked up your debt here.”

“I can live cheap!” Paris said, knowing full well his mother was the only force in his life that contributed to his frugality.

“Even so. Let's take food. The minimum price of a meal in the cafeteria is four drachs. You want to eat three times a day, that's twelve drachs per day. Over a fifteen-year contract term that's 67,700 drachs. And that's *if* you only ever eat that same slop that I did, which I think I'd rather die than eat that stuff

for a week straight, much less a year.”

Paris couldn't argue with that. “Yeah, but, the contract already covers boarding—”

“Which goes *up* if you want to make more income. Each rank puts fighters in better boarding and adds another five hundred drachs per year to your debt, so if you gained one rank per year that's another 33,000 drachs by the eleventh year. And then we get into the other debts. The average amount spent on medical expenses by any fighter is at least one thousand drachs per month.”

“Per month!?” Paris exclaimed.

“It's a fighting sport, please try to keep up. Fighters are responsible for their own purchases of Biomender Gel, which if you've seen the commissary prices, you'd better hope that one of those containers lasts you a while. I mean, you could forego Biomender, but then you wouldn't be earning income over the weeks it might take to heal naturally. And 'forego' isn't a realistic option because the company can force you to purchase if you're too far behind on your required fights. And that's assuming only the *occasional* incursion into the hospital, which as you've noticed already put you three months behind in medical expenses. Fifteen years, that's about 180,000 drachs if we're being optimistic.”

Paris's pineapple dropped to the concrete floor, bounced once and rolled along to a stop against Logan's hooves.

“Shall I go on?” Kinny gestured to his spreadsheet. “I have all the

minimum expected numbers right here.”

“No…” Paris slumped and laid back on his pillow.

“It’s nothing to be ashamed about,” Kinny said, tapping at the screen to close his programs. “The fifteen-year contract term is not an accident. The company wants as many of your prime years as they can squeeze out of you.”

Even if Paris worked his tail off to get up to Silver rank and clear his total debt, he’d be thirty-four. Practically an old rabbit! A geezer! That was most of his life right there, falling out like sands through an hourglass. He could have been continuing college but *no*, he was a dummy entranced by the glamor.

“Then why does anyone take the contract at all?” Paris asked. “Logan’s still here!”

“If you’re a bum like Logan, it’s still a good deal,” Kinny explained. Logan either didn’t notice the jab or just thought it accurate and continued to smile. “You accumulate debt, sure, but it’s like having a fifteen-year bar tab. So long as you’re under contract you don’t have to worry about earning money or paying it back or anything, you can just let it keep growing.”

“Until time’s up and you’re out on the street with no marketable skills and a negative balance in your account,” Paris said.

“Right, so the other option is to never leave,” Kinny said. “Keep renewing your contract for as long as they’ll let you.”

Logan’s smile grew wider.

Paris rarely considered his life long-term; everything in school that interested him, he was no good at. For years the only thing that concerned him

was chasing after some fantasy of settling down with some affable guy, even when St. Marten-Cristo didn't openly approve of his kind of relationships. What would he do after that? He didn't know. Just... hang around until he died, preferably from a mid-coital heart attack.

But he hated being so *trapped* here. Even if he had no plans to go anywhere or do anything else with his life, was he supposed to just live with this mistake? Accept this was his life now until the day they decided "we don't want a weakling rabbit anymore" and he was out and working crappy jobs for another fifteen years to pay off the rest of the debt? At which point, the day he turned fifty, he could *finally* start living his life again.

*Or... you could double up.*

It was the best idea that Paris'd had since he arrived.

"What if I get a regular job?" Paris asked, sitting up. "They only make us fight twice a week, and that's a lot of down time. I could double what they're paying me here."

"That'll be tricky," Logan said.

"Why?"

"It's part of the contract's 'public image' clause," Kinny said. "The company doesn't like it if their fighters 'look poor'."

*"I am poor and they're not helping!"*

"Outside of this building you're not allowed to discuss terms of the contract, you must disclose to all potential employers that you have a previous contract with Pit Fighters. All your wages earned from any side jobs will go to

the contract first.”

Paris stood and paced in front of the opossum. “Listen—none of that matters too much, right? I mean, yeah I don’t get spending money outside company scrip perhaps, but I’ll still pay off my contract faster.”

“He has a point, Kinny,” Logan said, sitting on the minifridge. “Money is money. And he is a healthy young bunny, if not overtaxed in the muscle department.”

“That’s just it! On-the-job strength training.” Paris said it like he was thinking about progressing in his fighting skills, but that was mostly to avoid disappointing Kinny.

The opossum was a *substantial* help with getting Paris to get in the right headspace to fight, but it took just one punch to ground him. The best someone like Paris could hope for was to tread water. And grand plans Kinny had about reaching Silver rank—if Paris could do that, why worry about money at all?

But he didn’t say it out loud. He rubbed at his face where the dissolving stitches still tingled.

“I could get a job as a dock worker—”

Kinny shook his head. “Can’t work at the docks. Too close to the ships. They worry you might try to stow away somewhere.”

Paris huffed. “What if I trained to become a fighting instructor?”

“The company has its own line of martial arts academies and you’d be competing.”

Logan spoke up, “And they *definitely* don’t allow prostitution.”

*“I didn’t say I was gonna—”* Paris clasped his paws over his face until he got his expression back to calm and proactive. “I mean, instead of going about this backwards, just tell me what *they* allow?”

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Paris, lightly enrobed in his red delivery cap and tiny vest, struggled to push the enormous cardboard package up a set of stairs much steeper than they had any right to be. Throwing his back against the long flat side that read THIS SIDE UP, he struggled to take a breath. The box threatened to topple and crush him against the tiny steps, so he reeled again and shoved with his legs, which were fortunately his best feature. The package wobbled upright, then toppled and tipped back, tapping against the doorframe. Paris skipped around the iron railing to reach the doorbell and rang it.

The door opened, and an enormous heavysset crocodile glanced at the package in front of him, now just leaning on the doorframe by its one corner. Paris ducked underneath, holding up the small tablet and a stylus.

“Delivery for Sowe Haran, sign here,” he said.

“Oh goodie,” the croc said, his voice more airy and jovial than Paris expected to come from his jagged teeth. He signed the tablet right away. “Oh, but I mean this to go in the garage, can you put it in there for me please?”

Paris looked back out across the porch to the garage twenty feet away, up a driveway with an equally absurd incline as the front steps.

“...yes, sir.” Paris sighed.

Some time later, Paris huffed and heaved, and the package landed with a loud *SLAP*, its long side landing against the empty concrete floor of the garage interior. Then he looked down and noticed the THIS SIDE UP arrow was now upside down. He whistled all the way back to his delivery van.

The electric vehicle started up, and Paris collapsed into the front seat. Then he sat up and looked into the bay in the back, noting again the sheer volume of cargo remaining.

“Delivery by eight p.m. my tail,” he grumbled, “No wonder they always leave the ‘sorry we missed you’ sticker without even trying to knock...”

With some trepidation in his muscles, he started the vehicle down to the next delivery...the very next house over. He then shut off the van and weakly checked the delivery roster on the tablet. This address had a lot of notes attached to it, and he didn't have the time to read all of that. He tapped the checkbox and reached into the back to find the box.

It was fortunately tiny and about the weight of a box of tissues. Paris sighed in relief, and ran up to the front door, finger jamming into the doorbell the moment he reached it.

The door opened, and a very busty female fox in an open silk robe answered the door. She looked Paris up and down, and leaned against the doorframe with one exposed leg sliding all the way to the other corner.

“Delivery for Lem Calor,” Paris said.

“Oh, that must be for my *husband*,” she said. She bent her knee and lifted

her leg far higher than required for any action. “I am so sorry, he is *out of town* for work and won’t be back until this *weekend*...”

“That’s fine,” Paris said, checking the tablet again and holding it out to her. “You can sign for it.”



“Hold on,” she said, standing straight and tall and letting her bust bounce around like a pair of overfilled water balloons. “Let me see if I have a *pen*, you can *step inside* if you like…”

“That’s okay ma’am, it’s digital—”

She disappeared anyway, leaving the door wide open. Paris tilted his head and stood there, waiting for her to return.

“Ma’am?” he called inside. “It’s all electronic. You don’t need a pen anymore.”

“Oh, but please *do* step inside,” she called back.

“I’m not allowed to enter the premises except to set the package within reach.”

“Then *come*, set it on the *table* for me.”

Paris shrugged and stepped inside. The decor of the place was not unexpected, just rather clean and posh with lots of bronze accents on the corners of every wooden counter and table and on the knobs of the tastefully modern upholstered furniture. Mrs. Calor sprawled across the dining room table fully disrobed, one leg up and exposing her rather swollen, moist genitals. Her enormous breasts now exposed the areolas of her nipples, which were themselves the size of dinner plates. Those breasts overall were at least as large as her head. Paris figured she had some work done, because there was no way that nature allowed any woman breasts of that size without some significant back problems.

“Is here fine?” Paris set the box on the table right in front of her.

“Why yes,” she said, turning and sweeping the package aside so it toppled to the floor. She leaned in closer. “So sweet to help out. Is there anything I can get you? Some tea? Coffee? Some…” she grabbed one of her tits and swirled her paw around the perimeter of her areola. “…milk, perhaps?”

“Your signature will be fine, ma’am,” Paris said, holding the tablet out again.

She pressed in closer until her boobs were pressing against Paris’s chest, and she took the pen from his hand and scribbled something there. When she handed it back, Paris noted that her tousling had smeared much of the electronic ink, leaving an unrecognizable signature.

Well, not his problem.

“Oops, I’m sorry,” she said, rolling her shoulders at him. “My breasts have *such* a habit of getting in the way—”

“No that’s fine,” Paris said, tipping his hat and turning. “Thank you, have a nice day!”

“Hey, wait!” she exclaimed, struggling to get off the table without falling. Paris was already out the door, though, and he double-checked the fancy brass house number and made a note of it on the spreadsheet. He was then in his delivery van when the front door of the house burst open wide, Mrs. Calor standing there without even a suggestion of her bathrobe. She started running down the steps toward the delivery truck, a manic grin on her muzzle.

“Did I forget something?” Paris asked himself, checking the item on the

list again. Nope! He called out the window, “Sorry, if you have a second package it’s on the evening route!”

He then drove off to the next destination, noting the figure in his rearview mirror trying to catch up with him. Well, it was a warm day. Maybe she was out for an afternoon jog.

—

Paris heaved the next package up yet another steep incline, contemplating whether he should ask for delivery jobs around the flatter parts of the island rather than the tall hills of the fancy neighborhoods. This place was fancier than any Paris had even been close to before; all the houses in this community were a minimum of three stories tall with all-original wood siding, white-washed fronts and slate gray roofs. It made Paris wonder how many of his extended family could live in just one of these houses—probably all of them—when they likely just fit a family of three. All of who were out most of the year jetsetting around the globe or going on fancy cruises.

Paris hefted the package and dropped it on the stoop—*bend with your knees, not your back*—and rang the doorbell as he checked the tablet again. The door swung open.

“Package for Alys Meyer—” Paris started.

“Oh, Mom’s thing came, huh?”

Paris froze and looked up from the tablet. The first thing he saw were the

paws, and he traced them all the way up the thick legs, cut abs and broad shoulders until he reached the face of the red spotted skunk Porte.

Paris's eyes bulged.

"Hey, bunny boy," Porte said, leaning against the doorframe with his arms crossed over his massive chest. "Scars healing up nicely."

"What are you doing here?!" Paris squeaked.

"I live here, dummy." He reached out a finger and flicked the brim of Paris's hat. "Cute duds. New to the delivery driver job?"

"Not necessarily!" Paris stammered. He didn't want Porte to know he was desperate for additional funds.

Porte, however, shook his head. "I haven't seen you on this route ever, I would have remembered. I'm guessing off the top of my head you realized you're totally in debt and you needed extra cash on the side and wanted to escape in a few years, huh?"

Paris froze, his back straightening until rigid. "Well, er, ah," he stammered, "I mean... you're in debt, too!"

Porte grinned. "Boy, please. I don't need to run around in a little electric tin can to make due—I can buy out my contract any time I like." He curled his fingers inward as if to check his claws. "So... you don't wanna be a fighter anymore, huh? Guess one hit from Santiago sent you packing. He's not even that good, he's just big."

Paris's teeth were clenching the longer Porte talked like this wasn't even a slight problem. "I swear to god," Paris creaked, "I will kick your ass again."

“Listen here, sweetie,” Porte looked up from his fingers, his stare turning cold. “We’re not in the ring. You throw a punch in my direction, that’s illegal and forbidden by our contracts. I’m also sure the delivery service looks down on arguing with your clients at their doorstep.”

“Then sign the damn thing so I can be on my way,” Paris growled through his teeth.

Porte shrugged and took the tablet, signing it excruciatingly slowly as Paris stared daggers at his face. He then looked it over for a full five seconds, looked to Paris, and held it out for him. Paris took it in both hands, but Porte held onto the tablet.

“So how much does a delivery boy make?” he asked.

“Enough,” Paris said, tugging, but Porte’s grip was powerful. “Let go, that’s company property!”

“You know…” Porte said, not even making a move like he would release the tablet anytime soon, “if you teamed up with me, I could make sure your debt isn’t hanging over your head.”

“You’re still on about that even after I beat you?” Paris asked.

“We still have an entire season to see if that holds,” Porte said. “I’ll admit, I underestimated you. I like boys with surprises in them. But I won’t underestimate you next time, sweetie.”

Porte yanked the tablet back, pulling Paris closer until he collided with Porte’s taut body. Paris almost bounced back, but Porte reached down, seized Paris by his rear and pulled him up into a kiss.

Paris gasped, his first thought being to slug Porte in the stomach to get him to back off—but his other brain took over almost at once. God damn it all, he was desperate for some kind of affection, even something so poisonous from the skunk, that he couldn't help himself, pressing in even closer to the dangerous boy, turning his head and kissing harder. Porte squeezed Paris's rear like a bath toy, and Paris almost jumped; at that point he would have followed the skunk all the way to his bed no matter what other objections he might have had.

*Oh god, I'm so hopeless...*

After what seemed like a full minute of kiss, Porte released Paris and let him drop back to the porch, which he landed on with his butt. The tablet dropped into his lap. Porte picked up the package with ease and teasingly propped it up on his hip.

"Stop by and see me sometime," he said with a wink. "There's always room for you." He closed the door.

Paris staggered back to his feet, clutching the tablet to his chest and not even bothering to hide his massive erection as he made his way back to the van. He leaned back against the seat, and the moment his right mind started coming back, he fumed.

"Bastard," he muttered. "You make it sound so enticing..."

Some part of him knew better than to trust Porte, even if he *wanted* to believe that just letting Porte have his way with him was the easiest path forward. After all, he *already* sold his soul to the company, what could Porte

offer that was worse?

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The next morning at the crack of before dawn, Paris untethered his alarm from his ear and switched it off. Several of the barracks beds were still creaking even at 3:30 in the morning; it was amazing how quickly Paris acclimated to the sound of everyone else having hot, exhausted sex all night.

He took the night trolley down to the distribution center and waved the pass stitched on the inside of his delivery vest for the door. The entire time, he was thinking about that evening—he had his next fight scheduled.

“Fortunately” the terms of his contract meant that the delivery company had to give sufficient time for Pit Fighters, so he would always have a sufficient block of time scheduled to get back to the stadium and get pummeled into the floor.

This morning, however, the algorithm had scheduled him to do processing. A huge truck straight from the docks backed into the loading bay and opened its doors. Multiple other delivery carriers jumped in and started pulling out and stacking the packages onto the middle of the open floor.

“Oh boy,” Paris said as he stared at the pile getting bigger and bigger. “I can’t wait to keep doing this for the rest of my twenties…”

He took his barcode scanner and beeped every package that ended up in his hands, then dumped it in front of the correct outlet for loading onto the correct delivery truck. Some packages the system directed into in the back

room for either delivery the next evening, tomorrow, or whenever—who was Paris to question the wisdom of the algorithm? He was its tool to carry the packages wherever they needed to go. He hefted another heavy one (was everyone on the island suddenly getting into weight lifting?) into the back room lined with rows upon rows of meticulously labeled steel shelves, whereupon he placed it in the correct aisle and row according to the readout.

Something brushed against Paris's tail. He turned.



Porte smiled down at him. “Hey, delivery boy,” he said.

Paris blinked, his brain locking up from the unexpected sight. “Porte,” he said after a long beat, “what are you doing here?”

“Your predicament intrigued me,” Porte said, clasping his hands together and pressing them to his cheek. “So I pulled some strings and here I am!”

“No!” Paris protested. “I’m not playing this game with you! I don’t care what you think you’re trying to do—”

“Is it wrong I want to see my bunny more often?”

“I’m not your bunny!”

“Hey!” shouted the manager from the door leading up to the security office, “Sorting doesn’t require talking!”

“It’s just what I was explaining to Paris here, Mr. Ingmar,” Porte said, hands clasped behind his back.

Paris stammered. “But he’s the one who—”

The manager approached, a warthog in a green shirt and tie. He barely fit between the shelves. “Is the new guy bothering you, Porte?”

“Not too badly, sir, don’t think less of him for it,” Porte said.

Oh, Paris could see where this was going, and his protestations would get him nowhere. It was not unlike public school. He just shut his lips and grabbed his barcode gun as he pushed around the manager to get back to the sorting floor.

Porte shadowed him the entire time, his groin brushing against Paris’s

tail multiple times, until Paris's backfur just all stood up on end.

"So you like sorting packages?" Porte asked with a grin. "That's meant as an innuendo."

"Porte, if you're gonna have a job here at least do the work," Paris grumbled.

"I am," Porte said. He tapped his own vest. "Floor supervisor. I'm supervising."

Paris stuttered. Porte leaned in to whisper in his ear.

"You can play ball or you can keep breaking the rules like a naughty bunny."

"Fine!" Paris waved him off. "Whatever!"

That seemed to satisfy Porte enough so he backed off to at least a token distance. Porte also checked out the asses of all the other male delivery personnel on the sorting floor, so Paris at the very least had the weight of Porte's eyes off his shoulders. He had room to shove around more heavy packages.

Still. Porte was here for a simple reason, and that was Paris. What he wanted *out* of Paris, he still was uncertain.

The very next package Paris beeped instructed him to place it in the back. When he arrived, Porte was already standing in the correct aisle, arm folded. God, he looked so hot standing there with a swagger on his hips.

"Bunny boy, let's talk," Porte said.

Paris shoved the package onto the shelf and muttered, "You're just going

to get me in trouble.”

“I can get you in trouble anyhow,” Porte said. “But I checked, nobody’s in the security booth.”

Paris sighed and accompanied Porte to the space in the back where they at least had enough room to breathe between them. “What,” Paris said flatly.

“Hey, not so harsh.” Porte laid a hand on Paris’s shoulder. “I just wanted to know if you thought about my offer.”

Paris’s ears flopped as he sighed. “I don’t know.”

“I know,” Porte said. “I made it sound a lot harsher than it was, but you know how it is with subs, some of them need a firm hand.”

Paris cocked an eye at the skunk. “I don’t know that.”

“Come on,” Porte said. “You’re a submissive, right?”

“Yeah, but up until I joined the Pit Fighters I didn’t know that many gay guys.”

Porte’s ears perked in surprise. “Really? Are you a virgin, then?”

“No!” Paris backed up, leaning against the wall and casting his eyes away. “I sucked a guy off before… once… it’s not like this city likes to talk out loud about it or anything.”

“I’m shocked,” Porte said. “I pinned you for a slut.”

“Hey!”

“Not in a bad way!” Porte said. “I freely admit I’m a slut, too. I’ve been around the block a few thousand times. Bunch of prudes out there, but they’re not the ones you worry about riding, you know?”

Paris blushed and refused to look up at the skunk.

“Listen, I feel kinda bad. Tell you what, no obligation, I’ll suck you off right now.”

Paris’s ears stood straight up so fast they made a *floomp* sound like an unfolding umbrella. He looked up at Paris and didn’t make a move. Well, he tried not to make a move, but his penis had other plans.

“That’s not a no!” Porte teased.

He lowered himself to his knees and slid his tongue up the soft length of Paris’s shaft. Paris let out a squeak of air as his knees buckled, the sheer ecstatic pleasure rocketing up his spine and turning his joints to gelatin. Not allowing him to fall, Porte slid his muscular arms under Paris’s thighs so he was sitting halfway on the skunk’s shoulders, and the rest of him braced against the over-painted wall.

Paris couldn’t believe he wasn’t objecting to this, but it was very hard to complain once Porte’s whole muzzle enveloped his cock. That warm and wet feeling around his tongue, the slight roughness sliding back and forth like a fine wet washcloth—Paris twitched and squirmed in place as he thought he could have exploded.

But Porte played gently, his head bobbing forward and back while his long, sharp teeth brushed against Paris’s sensitive parts. Somehow through it all, he kept that smug grin on his face, and glanced up at Paris with something approximating adoration on his eyes.

Paris couldn’t focus on anything—the sensations all seemed to collide

somewhere around his lower back, far too much to reach his brain at once. He felt numb, then overwhelming ecstasy. He bit down on his lip, his cheeks and whiskers twitching about foolishly. Something in him settled into the rhythm—somehow, he held on, as he grabbed Porte's headfur and rocked his own hips, thrusting in and out of the large warm maw.

"Porte—" Paris grunted, feeling the undeniable pressure under his legs, right where Porte's fingers pressed firmly into him. "Porte, I'm—"

His breaths quickened into shallow huffs, until he couldn't stand it any longer. He clenched his cheeks hard and thrust. Porte pulled off of Paris's cock, and Paris sprayed out a long rope of semen that crossed halfway down the back floor, some of it spilling onto Porte's lush tail and shoulder. Porte didn't seem to mind, as he continued to slide his teeth and tongue along Paris's erection sideways, sustaining the sensation. Paris erupted several times over, each one seeming to push the white fluid out so hard and satisfyingly. Paris collapsed against the wall as Porte let him back down to his feet.

"Damn," Porte said, licking the final bit off of Paris's tip. "You jizz like an elephant."

"Th-that wasn't fair," Paris said, huffing. He could have fallen asleep right there, and he wanted to, but forced himself to continue standing upright as his knees rattled.

"Oh, you can suck me off anytime," Porte said, licking Paris clean and standing up. He kissed Paris on the lips.

Paris pushed him away again. Some of his own cum brushed off of

Porte's shoulder and stuck to his fingers. "I mean," Paris said, looking up at the intimidating Porte again. He sighed. Even all of this wasn't enough to free his body from the intense delight he was still feeling. He wanted to bury himself in that soft and strong fur. "I mean," he made himself say, "I'm weak-willed and you know that."

"Hon," Porte said, "If you wanna say no, I gotta hear you say it."

"It's too late for that!"

"If you're worried about the whole virgin thing, don't," Porte said. "Most people's first time is terrible. You liked it, didn't you?"

"My cock would like a hole in a tree," Paris mumbled.

"I doubt that."

Porte pulled Paris in close and kissed him again. This time, Paris leaned into it without reservations, even though a little of Porte's breath smelled like semen. It didn't matter all that much to Paris in that moment, he just wanted this big strong skunk to hold on to him, to forgive him and keep him safe. Paris wanted to believe it so badly, just for a time he convinced himself it was the truth. He wrapped his legs around Porte's waist and his arms around Porte's shoulders, digging his tongue into that warm and skilled mouth, and finding safety there.

Paris had to stop himself before his hormone-addled brain started thinking things like *I love you, Porte*, because even that was a bridge too far for a fantasy. He pulled away, though Porte still looked at him with soft eyes and a sly smile, and his hands still stroked all along Paris's backside like he was all

ready for another round.

Paris may have considered it were he not so spent.

“Paris!” The manager screamed from the front of the stockroom. “Where are you!”

Paris squeaked. “Oh, god!”

“Get going, dummy!” Porte dropped Paris to the floor. He struggled to his knees—by then his erection had subsided. He started running back out, but then Porte whistled. Paris turned, and the barcode gun collided with his chest, and he scrambled to grab it before it hit the floor. Porte laughed and grinned in his direction. Paris pivoted, trying not to show how hard he was blushing as he scurried back to the sorting floor.

—

Paris set the brake on the delivery van. He slumped over the wheel, his ears flopping onto the dash. He couldn’t get the experience out of his head—dammit, it was so tempting! But it was humiliating. It wasn’t what he wanted. Porte wasn’t *who* he wanted.

But what were the odds of Paris getting what he wanted at this point? Settling for what *felt* like a decent second-place option was just...

Paris sighed and looked straight up the hill. This one was steep, and yet still had houses lining it all the way up the slope, placed so skewed that their sub-basements had outward-facing windows. He unlocked the brake and

attempted the climb, but his tires squealed, and the van slid all the way back down to the level street below.

“Stupid piece of junk!” Paris kicked the nearly bald offending tires. The tires did not respond, save to bounce his foot back the way it came and collide with his knee. Paris grumbled, got up, dusted his tush off, and reached into the back for the package.

This one was, as expected, heavy, and about as large as he was. Paris dragged it up the hill, counting the street numbers all the way up.

“What the hell is everyone ordering, anyway,” he muttered as he shoved the box another couple of feet at a time. “Rocks? Four-hundred-inch televisions? Automobiles?!”

The house in question was, of course, at the very top of the hill. Paris gasped as he thrust the box up the final four steps to the nice, pastel-blue deck, and he gave himself another minute to catch his breath as he rested, flopped over the box again. The sheer size of the door, twice his own height, showed they built the place for a very large individual. It was not unexpected, as most of the people of St. Marten-Cristo were so much taller than Paris was. The question was, why couldn't *they* drag the packages up the slope? Why was it that the weaker ones all had to do the hard work that'd take a matter of moments for the stronger?

Then he realized he forgot the tablet.

Four minutes and an exhausted climb later, Paris was fuming at himself, not even bothering with the niceties. He rang the doorbell and knocked on the

door multiple times, growling as he checked the entry on the delivery list. If this was the wrong house he swore...

The door opened.

"Package for Windel Orion," Paris muttered. "And please, if you need me to place it inside, don't—"

Paris looked up. His jaw dropped open.

*Is this—!?*

"Oh, it looks like my books have arrived," said the massive red-and-cream kangaroo. His voice was deep, but soothing like a massage chair. Paris couldn't help but throw his eyes all over the perfect specimen before him—shoulders almost as wide as he was tall, thick rippling abs, firm pecs, thick legs, and his... well, his...

Paris looked up before his dream-come-true noticed him staring at his crotch.

"S-S-Sultan?" Paris eked out.

Sultan didn't seem to hear him he was so quiet. "Thank you very much," he said, "I'll take that." He lifted the box up with his fingers, his enormous bicep barely flexing at all as he set the container inside. He then glanced at the tablet. "Do you need me to sign?"

Paris dropped the tablet, where it clattered to the wood deck.

"I take that as a no?" Sultan asked, lifting one of his thick eyebrows.

"*Oh my god!*" Paris blurted out. Then he tilted his ears. "Is your name really Windel?"

“Sultan’s my middle name,” he said. “Thought it had more of a punch to it. Fan, I presume?”

He turned and opened up the box with a quick flick of his claw and pulled out one of the books inside. The cover had a picture of him on an exercise machine with a pull bar over him, giving a rippling, succulent chiaroscuro image of his flexed backside. The title read *Zero to Sixty In Five Years*.

“Hey, have a copy on me,” Sultan said. “That’s what these are for.” He produced a pen and opened up the front cover. “Who do I make it out to?”

*Pop*. Paris felt lightheaded. “P-P-P-P-Paris, sir.”

“To Paris Sir.”

“N-n-n-n-o I mean P-P-P-P-Paris P-P-P-P-Patroni!”

“Is the stutter important?” Sultan asked with an amused grin. “How many P’s is that?”

“Sir—” Paris blinked, as his vision was getting blurry. “I’m—”

Sultan looked up. “Oh god, you’re bleeding! Did someone hit you?”

Yeah, that was the pop. Nosebleed again. Paris tried to explain the situation, how Sultan was so attractive and long-pined-for that Paris couldn’t help but develop a nosebleed, but before he got the first word out, he collapsed onto the deck.



When he woke up again, at first he startled, thinking he was back in the hospital, having lost even more of his income. But then he regained his focus, looking up to an unfamiliar ceiling. The couch he was lying on felt soft, far softer than anything he'd laid on for the last week.

He sat up, facing pale salmon pink walls framed with varnished wood molding. There was a lot of wood, largely in the form of knick-knacks atop white lace atop custom-carved wood cabinets, benches and mantles. The corners and edges were also sprawling with dark green leaves of various indoor vines and ferns.

Sultan appeared from the open passage to the dining room, wearing a cute pink apron that was just a little small for him. He beamed.

“Oh good! You're awake. I have some vegetable stew going, might help you rebuild some blood. But I won't keep you if you have somewhere to be.”

“...I...” Paris started, still dazed and stupefied by his hero standing right before him, but slightly less dumbfounded. Something about the pink apron made him seem a little more normal, if one could call an enormous kangaroo in a pink apron normal. “I have a few minutes,” he said. “Just, you know! A few more deliveries!”

That was a blatant lie, but he was not about to pass up the opportunity to bask in Sultan's presence.

“Of course!” Sultan said, turning and returning to the kitchen. “And don't worry about imposing, I'm always entertaining fans one way or another. You

okay to stand or you want me to bring you some there?”

Paris nearly fell off the couch trying to get a good look at Sultan’s butt, though his tail obscured half of it. “Uh, here is okay,” he said, looking up to the knit blanket draped over the back of the couch. He grabbed it and laid it across his lap.

Sultan returned with a small folding table in one paw and a vast steaming bowl in the other. He set them up before Paris in a single gesture, and Paris looked at his reflection in the brown swimming pool before him.

“This is a lot of stew,” he said.

“I won’t be insulted if you don’t finish!” Sultan stood there, looming and looking down, waiting to see the reaction on Paris’s face.

Paris, feeling the spotlight upon him, grabbed the spoon as large as one of his mom’s soup ladles and dipped it into the bowl and brought it to his lips. His ears lifted as he sipped.

“This is *amazing*,” he said, his eyes tearing up from the sheer complexity of the flavors. He wouldn’t have even realized it was just vegetables if Sultan hadn’t said it was vegetable soup. Dark flavors layered over light, with a sweet floral component and a deep rich one behind it, just thick enough to not feel watery but not so thick as to feel pasty.

Paris looked up to his hero with even greater admiration in his eyes. “I didn’t know you cook!”

Sultan beamed. He almost looked cute like that, his big firm and serious face giving way to cheerful round and fuzzy features. “You kinda have to learn

at my level,” he said. “There’s only so many times a guy can eat chicken and rice before color drains from the world. And I can’t eat what passes for food at restaurants around here.”

Paris tilted his ears. “Not even the cafeteria food at the Pit Fighters stadium?”

Sultan snorted. He took a seat on the big plush recliner next to the couch, slipping his tail through the hole in the back. “That garbage? I’d rather chew my arm off.”

“Even the top-level stuff?” Paris tilted his head the other way as he slurped up more delicious soup.

“I’m not paying them extra for even the mediocre food.” Sultan peeled off the apron and draped it over the arm of the chair. Paris had to look away lest he catch himself staring at Sultan’s prodigiousness again. “Honestly that’s the worst thing about starting out in Pit Fighters—the rest you can get used to. The schedule. The injuries. The constant press. You’re not press in disguise, are you?”

“No,” Paris said, staring at the soup.

“Good, cause if you were I’d smash all your cameras and throw you down the hill.” He laughed so hard the folding table shook, putting ripples into the soup’s surface. “Know what my mom always said? Be kind to everyone you meet, but brook no bullshit.”

“Must be nice being super rich and famous. Sir.” Paris mumbled.

“Oh, it’s *nice*, but people make out fame to be something bigger than

what it is. Being famous just means people talk about you more. If people have mixed opinions about you before, fame doesn't revise those *opinions*."

Paris nodded. He didn't get it, but he nodded. "Well, I like you, sir." He said, trying to suppress his stutter as he admitted it. "I mean, you're kinda a hero to me. I've... I don't know what to say! I've been trying my entire life to meet you, but well, my family lives down in the downriver district... I never got to see you much outside of television. I didn't even know you had a house here, shows how big a fan I am."

Sultan laughed again. He folded his arms behind his head and crossed one leg over his knee. "If you sought me out, I would have a very different opinion on your presence."

"To tell you the truth, sir, I did kinda... I um... well a while ago I was walking home and I saw the recruitment posters for Pit Fighters, and I—well, I thought maybe one day I'd get to see you, so I joined up."

Sultan's expression dropped, his smile vanishing.

"Dammit," he muttered, standing up and pulling back the lace curtains to look out the window again.

"What's wrong?" Paris asked.

"I hate them using my face on the recruitment posters."

"But I thought you liked Pit Fighters! Why else keep renewing your contract?"

Sultan turned again to face Paris, this time his expression more like Paris was used to seeing, fierce, serious, critical. He paced back and forth on the rug.

“Because I’m on top. Of course *I’d* like it, I get all the benefits. But they mean for the whole ranking process to grind young men into hamburger meat. It seems to happen like clockwork every year. A fresh batch of faces. Spirits get broken. Debts pile up. If they *do* get out, several end up in prison.”

“I’m not gonna be like that.”

“Is that why you’re working a delivery job immediately after you joined?” Sultan stood before Paris like some kind of ancient statue. “Cause the way the company has this island wrapped around their finger, you’re not getting extra spending money. Think you’re gonna pay your way out early?”

Paris shrank into the couch, blushing hard. “Um… maybe?”

Sultan sighed. His thick shoulders sank. “Just joined and you already want out.”

“I didn’t know, okay!” Paris blurted. “I know, I’m not too bright. I’m still not even sure what I want. One of my fri—rivals said if I just helped him out with his scheme he’d help me with my debt, and I was thinking—”

“Okay, Paris…”

Sultan took up the couch seat next to him and put an enormous arm around. Paris was very thankful he thought to put the blanket over his lap, because this touch was far, far more than his body could handle, diverting all of his blood to his genitals at once.

“Listen to me,” The kangaroo said, “Rule one of self-management: until it’s in your hand, never believe promises of money.”

“But he’s rich…” Paris said, swooning and desiring to bury himself under

Sultan's arm.

"I know a lot of rich folk. They don't stay rich by spending huge sums on charity cases. They stay rich by stringing people along with promises. And you don't know how rich this character is, he could be making it up to get in your head."

"Yeah, but what about you?" Paris said, trying to keep from giggling like a schoolgirl. "You seem nice..."

Sultan pulled his arm away and sat back. "I don't believe I offered to pay off your debt."

"I know!" Paris exclaimed, shaking his head out of the swoon-space. "I'm not saying you should! That'd be super rude of me to even suggest!" He paused and thought about it. "I mean, unless..."

"I'm not going to deny I have means. But how rich do you think I am?"

Paris raised a finger and opened his mouth to throw out a suggestion, but then he realized that he barely had a concept of how much money was a lot of money. He'd only ever lived on one end of the bell curve, so everyone above him just seemed like some generic "rich person" level of wealth. "Uh," he said, "This house is nice... I'd think you're a millionaire?"

Sultan slapped his knee and *laughed*, this time rattling the spoon inside the bowl of vegetable soup. Paris shrank again, pulling his knees up to his chest.

"Believe it or not," Sultan said, wiping a tear from his eye, "*most* of my money is still in company scrip. But even then, I can't go around paying off new fighters' debts. A lot of what you see here is the company seeking to stay on my

good side—if they had reason to suspect I was trying to undermine their scheme, I stand to lose even more. Don't force me to make that decision for someone I just met, especially someone who isn't even going to stand on their two legs. You will not like the answer.”

Paris curled up, burying his face between his knees.

“Hey!” Sultan said, stroking Paris along his back. “Cheer up! You are right in one regard—I try to keep abreast of the new guys; we might see each other again! Logan still hanging around?”

Paris looked up, somewhat confused. “Uh, yeah, he is. I think he's taken to me…”

“I figured,” Sultan said. “He's a layabout, but he means well. Stick by him, he'll keep you afloat.”

“Really?” Paris tilted his head again.

“Well if you're not gonna believe the greatest superstar in all of St. Marten-Cristo, who can you believe?”

Paris wasn't sure. Sultan was right, and Paris felt like a total mooch for even *suggesting* that his hero could just throw money at this problem to solve it. He considered just slithering out the door and back down the street right then, but then looked up at the fancy ornate clock above the mantle. Paris squeaked.

“Is that time right?!” He asked.

“Huh?” Sultan looked up. “Oh, you're right, that one's off.”

Paris sighed as Sultan recused himself from the couch, lowering Paris back down to equilibrium. He sighed and tried to relax again. Then Sultan set

the clock ahead by an hour.

“Glk,” Paris intoned.

“Daylight savings,” Sultan said. “Always miss one.”

“Four o’clock!?” Paris jumped up from the sofa. “I still have ninety packages to deliver in four hours!”

He scrambled all around the living room looking for his hat. It appeared on his head, with Sultan giving him two pats that nearly sent Paris into the floor.

“Buck up!” Sultan said. “You can make something even of this.”

Paris swallowed. “I’d like to believe that, sir,” he said. “But… I mean, you’re so big and strong and I’m… me.”

“That’s still good. Rule two of self-management: being yourself is the best thing you can be. Much easier than trying to be someone else.”

“Maybe,” Paris said. “But I’m worried that the me who I am is… just a poor fit for what I got myself into.”

“Mmm, perhaps,” Sultan said. He opened up the door and bowed his head a little. “But you won’t know until you try.”

—

Paris returned to the base of the hill only to find the delivery van missing. He panicked at first—thinking someone had stolen it, because what else would a bored kid in an upscale neighborhood do? Those things had tracking built-in to them so at the very least Paris reassured himself he was off the hook for an

unforeseeable faux pas. So, he ran down the hill all the way back to the distribution center to report the missing vehicle.

A van with the exact same number surprised him outside the loading bays. Tilting his ears, Paris went to the manager's office. He quickly wished he hadn't bothered.

"What do you mean I'm fired?!" Paris exclaimed to the warthog in the green shirt who sat behind a desk with a very dour expression and his hands folded. The only thing on the desk was a little plaque reading *Hari Ingmar*. The only other furniture in the room was a single dented filing cabinet.

The warthog, however, produced a manila folder from the ether and laid it down in front of him. "Porte already told me about it. You know that masturbating on the premises is considered a biological hazard?"

Paris stopped. *Of course*. The entire plot came together in an instant—nothing Porte did was out of his good nature. He felt a trickle of rage rise from his stomach all the way to the top of his head. Gritting his teeth, he stammered, "Th-this is stupid! Porte *only* got himself hired here so he could get me fired!"

The warthog raised an eyebrow. "Are you saying you *didn't* spread your semen all over the floor of the storage room?"

"Well... where's the proof?"

The manager flipped open the manila folder. The photocopied page he turned to read *Lab Results* at the top.

"Goddammit." Paris didn't need to read the rest.

"One of the conditions of your work is that you abide by the rules of AES

Inc, so they're more than willing to help contribute to DNA testing."

Paris considered protesting further, stuttering and posing his hands this way and that, but there was no point trying to explain it to the manager here. What would he have to gain? Even if he could somehow keep his job here, Porte would just do this all over again. And if Paris turned this around on Porte, Porte would quit anyway because what did he need this job for?

The manager droned on as Paris sulked in place. "Normally this would go along with a misdemeanor charge and a fine, but I don't wish to drag this out before a court, now, would you?"

"No..." Paris muttered.

More paperwork later and handing in his hat and vest, Paris was once again wandering around the city plaza with nothing. He'd barely made 18 drachs while he worked for the delivery company, which went to the Pit Fighters anyway. He sulked around the garden strip throughout the afternoon, until the sun set and the lights came on, lighting the place up like a festival night. It would have been nice if there was a festival, not that Paris could have taken part, as he had a fight to attend in two hours. He sighed and slumped down on a well-polished park bench, facing the congregation of food vendors that Paris didn't have the free change to purchase from. His stomach rumbled. He should have eaten more of that soup while he was at Sultan's place.

*Heh... almost forgot I met my hero today... seems like a week ago now. I botched that up too. Wonder what he'd say when he realizes how badly I screwed myself over.*

“Me and my stupid dick,” Paris muttered.

“Well, I wouldn’t call you a stupid dick,” said Porte’s voice. “That’s a little harsh.”

Paris’s fur riled up his backside. He stood, turning to face the red skunk, who clasped his hands behind his back, smirking like he had a dirty secret.

“You!” Paris growled.

“Hey, sorry about all of that,” Porte said, stepping in and leaning down to speak with Paris face-to-face. “But listen: the delivery service was in direct competition with me for *you*. I’m offering a lot more, and now you don’t have to waste your time with packages. I did you a favor.”

Oh, that was *it*. Paris’s fists clenched into a tight ball. He was past angry. He was *enraged*.

“I didn’t ask you for a damn favor,” he said.

He struck Porte right against his muzzle. The cartilage distended. Porte staggered back, blood flowing from his bruised nose. He righted himself and opened his mouth as if to say something, but Paris wasn’t even willing to fake listening. He leaped atop Porte and kicked him straight onto the stone tiles of the plaza. Porte grabbed at Paris to throw him off, but Paris made himself heavy, throwing all of his weight into Porte’s collar as he rammed his fists down into the skunk’s face over and over and over again.

Porte seized Paris by his scruff and threw him aside. Paris tumbled until he struck the back of a hot dog cart. The people all around there backed away, some calling for someone named “police”. Paris staggered upright. Just as Porte

was dusting himself off, Paris tackled him again, this time right into the bushes of the park strip. Porte fell tangled into the branches; he yelped as some of them cut into his back, but Paris didn't care. He rammed his knee into Porte's gut, knocking all the wind out of him, and then caught his neck in both paws before he could take another breath.

Paris squeezed. Porte flailed and shoved, but with his shoulders and back jabbed awkwardly by branches underneath, he had no leverage, and Paris did not let go.

That was until another pair of hands seized Paris and slapped handcuffs to his wrists. Paris shrank, his anger turning to fear, as he noticed the black canine police officer staring down at him.

"H-hey!" Paris said as the canine seized him by the nape of the neck.

Behind him, Porte coughed and sputtered. "Yes, officer, you saw him attack me! I was just defending myself!"

"You bastard!" Paris attempted to throw himself back into the fray, but the police officer handled him easily with his wrists locked together. He hefted Paris over his shoulder like a sack of flour.

Porte did his best to look like he had this all under control—though he staggered out from the bushes and winced, glaring at Paris all the while bleeding from his nose and mouth.

Paris sank. It didn't matter at this point how badly he beat Porte in another fight. Porte won anyway.

---

After processing, the police officer dropped Paris off in a concrete brick box facing a hallway that had two others in it. The barrel-chested, burgeoning officer was himself uncomfortably hot, and Paris had heard rumors about prison. Fortunately the officer asked for no favors. He said very little, leaving Paris behind the bars of the cell and exiting through the open doorway. A camera in the hallway stared down at Paris. A television up in the far corner played sports news in fuzzy static.

Paris sighed and turned back to the cell. Two bunks that were slabs of sheet metal and a single toilet meant for a larger occupant. Paris laid down on the bed and sulked, calling himself many horrible names in his head the entire time. How long was he going to be here, anyway?

It didn't take long before the officer dragged through another prisoner, a pink hippo, this one much louder and more protest-y than Paris had been.

"I didn't do it!" the hippo said, his voice rather light and squeaky like a cartoon character. "You can't prove it was me!"

"That's for the judge to decide," the canine officer said with all the rote memorization of a spelling bee contestant. He opened up the jail door and shoved the hippo inside before locking it again and leaving.

The enormous hippo called out several more things at the bars. "I'll get my lawyer on this! Police brutality! Discrimination! All sorts of scary things upon your head—ooooh! Ghosts and furies and things of that nature!"

The officer had left earshot, so the hippo grunted and sat down—right on top of Paris.

“Hey hey hey hey!” Paris yelped.

“Whoops, sorry,” The hippo said, swinging his enormous rear end around so he was sitting on the opposite bed instead. The metal bowed under his weight. “Didn’t see you there.”

“Yeah, I guess I am small and pathetic,” Paris said, turning so he laid on his back.

“Yeah,” the hippo said. He said nothing else.

Paris glared at him. *You didn’t have to agree...*

“What’re you in for?” The hippo asked.

“Punching a dickhead in the plaza.”

“Oooh! The hippo seemed to light up at this, clasping his wristless hands together in delight. “Did he deserve it?”

Paris grunted. “He got me fired two days into my new job. Yes he deserved it. And *now* because of him I’m gonna miss the *legal* fight I was supposed to have—what time is it?”

“Processing office said eight fifty-seven.”

“Right now!” Paris sprang up from his bed and stared out into the hallway, but just ended up banging his head against the bars. “Aaaaaagh!”

“No hitting the bars,” the officer called from the black doorway beyond.

“Oh, so you’re with the Pit Fighters?” The hippo asked.

“Yeah,” Paris muttered, slumping into the bars so his arms laid against

the cross-brace.

“Don’t think I’ve seen you on TV before,” the hippo said. “Boy, you musta clocked that guy real good.”

“I’d like to think so, but no. He wanted me to hit him so I’d end up here.”

“Yeah, that’s how it is.” The hippo nodded. “Course, you know the secret to getting the better of someone like that.”

Paris turned to look at the hippo. “What… not let them rile you up?”

“Better! When you hit them…” the hippo looked around like someone would eavesdrop in their cell with them, and he put a hand up to cover his mouth and whispered, “…you gotta kill them. That way you got the last laugh.”

Paris stared at him. He slipped off the bars and returned to his bunk, laying down and curling up. “Thanks,” he muttered. “I’ll keep it in mind.”

“Don’t mention it!” the hippo intoned.



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It didn't take very long before the hippo was at the bars of the cell, wiggling his rear like a giddy schoolkid at the television, which played that evening's Pit Fighter exhibition matches. It wasn't like Paris would have been on TV that evening anyway, the lowest rankings rarely made it onto television.

Paris considered how he was a massive disappointment to everyone. They'd lower his ranking for sure—being a no-show was worse than losing. Probably would drop even more once the company learned of his incarceration. If he was lucky, his rank would drop below 100 and then… well, Dyna never explained what would happen. Maybe he'd be ground into literal hamburger meat.

He sighed. None of Porte's actions were the least bit benevolent, no matter how much Paris wanted to wish things were different. Porte would just try harder and harder to break him. And Paris considered he'd just let Porte win. There was no way he could fight this—he had nothing, and Porte had everything. Sultan's idea of fighting back was nice, but even his hero agreed that Paris was unlikely to succeed. And right now it seemed like Sultan was still more naive than he expected. Unless one had muscles like a marble god, the dirtier, underhanded fighter with the most resources would always, always win.

Paris sighed and clasped his paws over his ears as the hippo burst into cheers, followed by the officer's admonitions. He tried to shut out all the noise,

given he just felt so tired now.

He didn't know when he'd fallen asleep, but Paris woke up sometime with morning light peeking in through the single slim barred window near the ceiling. The black canine officer rapped at the bars.

"Paris Patroni?" The guard asked.

"What," Paris muttered.

"Your fine's been paid. Come with me."

Paris blinked. He sat up. Did the company make a habit of bailing out their fighters? That seemed unlikely, and he really, *really* hoped his mom hadn't learned of this. He'd never stop scrubbing the kitchen floor if she'd dipped into the family savings for this, on top of her... well, he'd seen what she could do with a fish scaler.

Paris followed the officer to processing, at which point they handed Paris a bag of his belongings, which was odd as he was naked at the time of the incident. Still, the plastic bag had his name on it. Once he took it out of the glare of the harsh police station lights, he noticed it was a book, and he turned it over. *Zero to Sixty in Five Years.*

He removed the book from the bag and opened up the front cover.

*Hey champ, I figured I might have sounded a skosh discouraging, plus you forgot your book, so I went to see your fight tonight. You didn't show up. I poked around a bit and learned that you'd been fired, scuffled with one of the other Greens and got stuck in jail. I can't say I'm not a little disappointed, but then again, I know a set up when I see one. I convinced Dyna to only drop your*

*score by a normal loss amount. Take this opportunity to prove me right, because at the very least I want to believe you're a good kid who acted a bit foolish.*

*You might be curious because I said I wasn't gonna help you out with money, but there isn't a single fighter worth his salt that hasn't made mistakes. It shows you have spirit. While I'm big on self-reliance, even I know we gotta get a little outside help once in a while. — Windel*

*P.S. not signing my stage name cause I don't want you selling this for cash. You're not a bum, you're a fighter, act like it. I want to see improvement in you next time we meet.*

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“It’s a little condescending that Sultan thought I’d sell his signature for money!” Paris exclaimed once back in the bunk room.

“Would you?” Kinny asked, sitting on the bed across from Paris’s.

Paris opened his mouth to speak, then scrubbed the back of his neck awkwardly. “Well… I might consider it, but *probably* not!”

Logan looked at the open book over Paris’s head from the bunk above. “His name is Windel?”

“That’s what I asked!”

“So, what now?” Kinny asked. “You lucked out and made an impression on the most famous fighter on the island who saved your score from the slag heap. Got a second chance. Gonna get another job?”

“Maybe later,” Paris said. “But Porte’s just going to keep shadowing me

until I give in. Well, I won't. I'm done with being shy about this! I need to focus on beating *Porte* before anything—and if I lose, at least I'll lose *fighting him*.”

“A talk with the king of fighters and a night in the slammer seems to have done you wonders,” Kinny noted.

“It's…” Paris muttered. “That's personal growth. That's all on me. This is my doing.”

“Mmm,” Kinny nodded with a cynical stare.

Paris glared at Kinny for a long moment. Who was this little punk to decide that Paris was stagnant, anyhow?

“So,” Kinny finally said, leaning back on his palms. “Is Sultan just as hot in person?”

“*God* yes!” Paris exclaimed. “He'd better mean it about meeting up again sometime! Otherwise I'm gonna…”

“Masturbate until your cock falls off?”

“… not necessarily!”

TO BE CONTINUED.



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This is a story by Rick Griffin. Be sure to check out other stories, comics, and artwork by visiting [rickgriffinstudios.com](http://rickgriffinstudios.com).

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